

floatCSEP: An application to deploy and conduct reproducible, prospective earthquake forecasting experiments

Pablo Iturrieta ^{1¶}, William H. Savran ², Marcus Herrmann ³, José A. Bayona ⁴, Matthew C. Gerstenberger ⁵, Kenny Graham ⁵, Philip J. Maechling ⁶, Warner Marzocchi ³, Leila Mizrahi ⁷, Danijel Schorlemmer ^{1,7}, Francesco Serafini ⁴, Fabio Silva ⁶, and Maximilian J. Werner ⁴

¹ GFZ Helmholtz Centre for Geosciences, Potsdam, Germany ² University of Nevada, Reno, United States ³ Università degli Studi di Napoli Federico II, Naples, Italy ⁴ School of Earth Sciences, University of Bristol, Bristol, United Kingdom ⁵ GNS Science | Te Pū Ao, Lower Hutt, New Zealand ⁶ Southern California Earthquake Center, University of Southern California, United States ⁷ Swiss Seismological Service at ETH Zürich, Zürich, Switzerland ¶ Corresponding author

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Summary

floatCSEP is a Python application that standardizes and orchestrates the workflow of earthquake forecasting experiments. Based on principles established by the Collaboratory for the Study of Earthquake Predictability (CSEP, <https://cseptest.org>), it enables reproducible, transparent, and reusable experiments to evaluate earthquake forecasts. floatCSEP builds on the existing pyCSEP toolkit for core evaluation routines and adds the functionality needed to deploy and conduct entire experiments, including catalog handling, forecast generation, evaluation, visualization, and reporting. Accompanying tutorials illustrate experiment use cases, which users can extend to incorporate new models, alternative evaluation metrics, or different regions and timeframes. Ultimately, the goal of floatCSEP is to support new official CSEP experiments and to encourage independent researchers to validate their own models.

Background

Earthquake forecasts are probabilistic statements about future earthquake occurrence ([Jordan et al., 2011](#)) and are used to inform building codes, emergency response planning, and risk reduction strategies. Because earthquake occurrence is driven by complex and highly non-linear processes (e.g., [Geller, 1997](#); [Kagan, 1994](#)), forecasts should be expressed and evaluated in a probabilistic framework designed to describe their fundamental uncertainties ([Kagan & Jackson, 1994](#)). Assessing forecast reliability is further challenged by the large timescales required to collect sufficient observations for evaluation (especially of large earthquakes) and the multiple subjective biases from any post-hoc adjustments in modeling or evaluation environments (e.g., [Schorlemmer & Gerstenberger, 2007](#)). To address such challenges, the Collaboratory for the Study of Earthquake Predictability (CSEP) was established to facilitate rigorous, prospective forecasting experiments where all forecasting models, data sources, evaluation metrics, and related software are defined prior to the evaluation period (e.g., [Jordan, 2006](#); [Schorlemmer et al., 2018](#)). CSEP experiments were carried out in so-called Testing Centers, i.e., hardware and software infrastructure designed to ensure (i) controlled access, (ii) reproducible environments for automated forecast generation, and (iii) long-term archiving of input data, metadata, and results ([Zecher et al., 2010](#)). With this framework, CSEP has successfully hosted and published

experiments across diverse geographic regions, such as California, New Zealand, Italy, Japan, and globally (Bayona et al., 2021, 2022, 2023; Eberhard et al., 2012; Field, 2007; Gerstenberger & Rhoades, 2010; Iturrieta et al., 2024; Nanjo et al., 2011; Strader et al., 2018; Taroni et al., 2014, 2018; Tsuruoka et al., 2012; Werner et al., 2010; Zechar et al., 2013). These efforts have substantially advanced scientific rigor and established community standards in earthquake forecasting research, thereby contributing to better forecasts and seismic hazard assessments (e.g., Michael & Werner, 2018; Schorlemmer et al., 2018).

Statement of Need

Despite their achievements, the original CSEP Testing Centers used centralized, rigid software architectures that tightly coupled data management to local hardware, limiting reuse, scalability, and community engagement (e.g., Savran, Bayona, et al., 2022; Schorlemmer et al., 2018; Zechar et al., 2010). As noted by Mizrahi et al. (2024), there is broad consensus in the earthquake forecasting community that transparency and reproducibility are essential in forecast testing. However, due to the complexity of Testing Centers, independent researchers often require advanced technical expertise to access, reproduce, and analyze CSEP experiments. To overcome these limitations, the Python package pyCSEP (Graham et al., 2024; Savran, Bayona, et al., 2022; Savran, Werner, et al., 2022) was developed to provide core forecast evaluation routines that can be directly integrated into modelers' workflows.

However, pyCSEP alone lacks key features required to deploy and conduct entire forecasting experiments, such as interfacing with external models' source code, automating catalog access, managing data, standardizing workflow execution, and generating summary reports. Therefore, additional software is required that provides Testing Center capabilities while remaining decoupled from specific hosting hardware. To meet this need, we developed floatCSEP, which manages the entire experiment lifecycle, from model integration and initial deployment to the incremental updating of input data, forecasts, results, and reports as new observations become available. It is intended for earthquake forecast model developers, institutions that run CSEP-style forecasting experiments, and the broader statistical seismology community. To our knowledge, no existing software provides this complete end-to-end testing workflow; commonly used seismology tools instead address only individual steps, such as catalog queries (e.g., ObsPy, Beyreuther et al. (2010)) or forecast evaluation (e.g., pyCSEP).

Software Overview

The primary objective of floatCSEP is to provide a portable, automated, and reproducible Testing Center environment that runs on a standard workstation (subject to experiment-specific runtime and memory demands) and scales to HPC systems for computationally intensive experiments, such as time-dependent models producing daily forecasts. Experiments are defined through human-readable YAML (yaml.org) configuration files, which are processed through a simple command-line interface to ensure ease of use even for users without extensive computational expertise. This declarative approach simplifies the experiment setup, standardizes its workflow (Figure 1) and enhances its reproducibility.

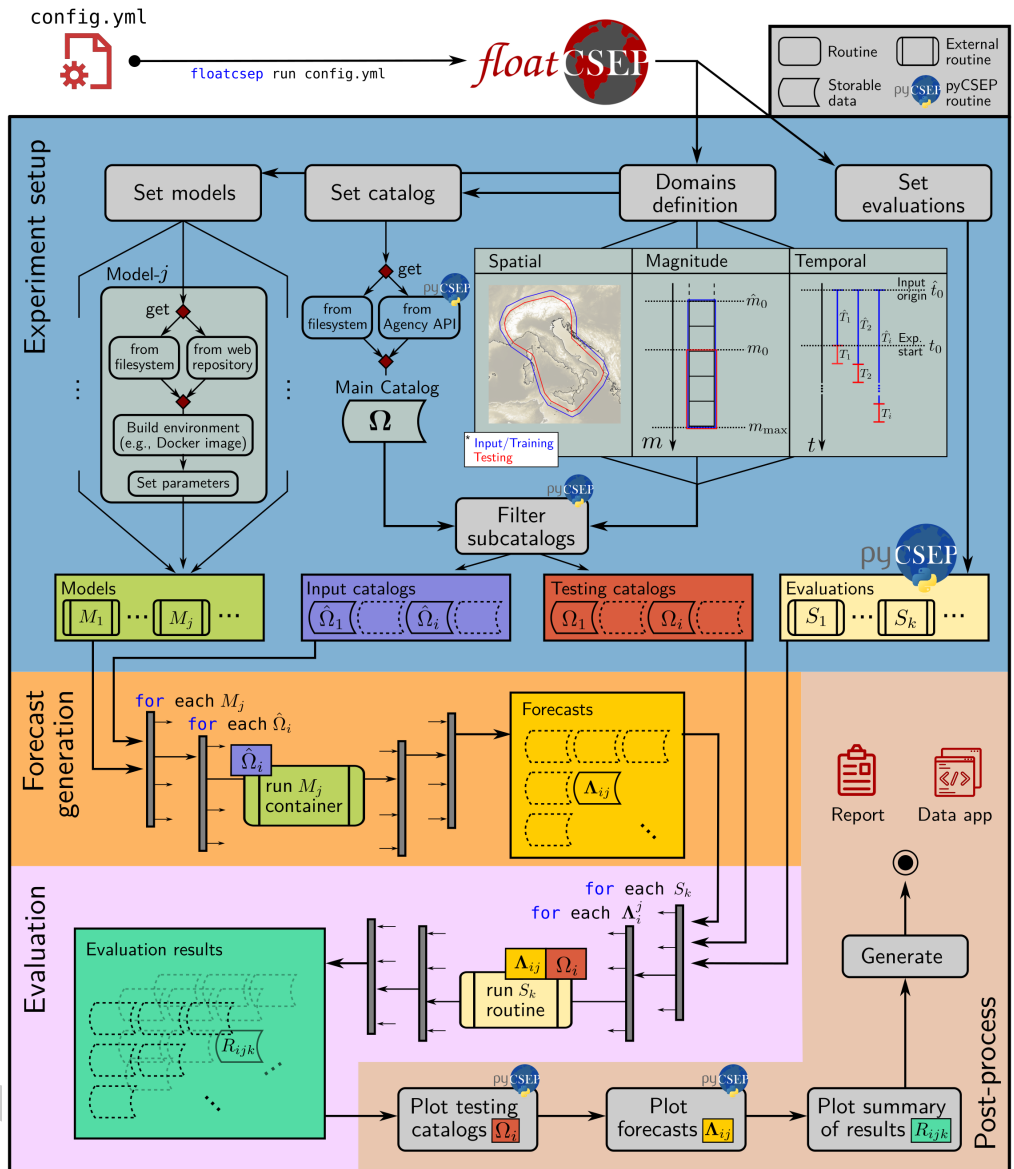


Figure 1: Workflow diagram of floatCSEP for a time-dependent experiment, which roughly consists of: 1) Defining time-space-magnitude ranges and discretizations for forecast generation and evaluation; 2) Querying and filtering earthquake catalogs (both for model input and evaluation); 3) Building the source code of external models, configuring its parameters and input data; 4) Generating forecasts by running each model's source code in a containerized environment; 5) Performing forecast evaluations and comparisons using pyCSEP's or user-implemented testing metrics; and 6) Producing reports including test results and visual representations.

floatCSEP uses pyCSEP as a dependency, incorporating its core functionality (forecast and catalog classes, and evaluation routines) alongside additional Testing Center operations, such as data management and computational containerization using Docker (Merkel, 2014). The application supports multiple forecast formats and accommodates both time-invariant and time-variant experiments. It handles forecasts produced either by models managed directly by floatCSEP or provided externally through raw files. Representative use cases are included as tutorials, which users can extend by incorporating new models, adding alternative evaluations, or replicating in different regions and timeframes. The software integrates

seamlessly with pyCSEP's existing testing routines and provides custom hooks for user-defined tests, visualizations, and reports.

Example Use

An example configuration file (config.yml) for a time-invariant, grid-based experiment in Italy with two models is shown in Figure 2.



config.yml

```
name: CSEP Experiment                                * Experiment metadata
time_config:                                         * Temporal definition. Additional parameters
  start_date: 2010-1-1T00:00:00                    can create multiple windows
  end_date: 2020-1-1T00:00:00
region_config:                                       *Spatial and magnitude definitions (set jointly
  region: italy_csep_region                          as in pyCSEP format). region can refer to a
  mag_min: 3.95                                       CSEP existing region or to a file containing cell
  mag_max: 8.95                                       nodes
  mag_bin: 0.1
  depth_min: 0
  depth_max: 70
catalog: query_bsi                                  * Either a pyCSEP function or external file
models:
  - Smoothed-Seismicity:
    path: ssm.dat                                     * Model's configuration. Can point to a file,
  - Spatially-Uniform:                               source code or web repository (e.g., github).
    path: uniform.dat                                Model parameters are also set here
tests:
  - S-test:
    func: poisson_evaluations.spatial_test           * Tests to be carried out. Can point to
    plot_func: plot_consistency_test                 pyCSEP or custom functions.
```

floatcsep {run, stage, plot, reproduce, view} config.yml

Figure 2: Simplest example of a configuration file for a time-invariant, grid-based experiment with two models. The run command executes the experiment end-to-end, generating and testing all missing forecasts from the last execution up to today. The stage command accesses and builds the models' source code, as well as preparing input and testing catalogs. The reproduce command re-executes an experiment and compares it with existing results using statistical and computational metrics. plot executes the post-process, image generation, and reporting of the experiment. view deploys a data app for visualizing the forecasts, catalogs, and test results.

Applications

floatCSEP is designed to support the following applications:

- Deploy and conduct new prospective experiments that incrementally incorporate new data, update forecasts, and provide evaluation results. While the CSEP community plans to use floatCSEP for new (official) experiments, we also encourage independent researchers to adopt floatCSEP to prospectively evaluate their models.
- Reproduce the results of completed prospective CSEP experiments within a containerized computational environment (e.g., Iturrieta et al., 2024).
- Create new retrospective or pseudo-prospective experiments for their easy reproduction and shareability.
- Plug new models into a completed or ongoing (float)CSEP experiment. Since CSEP experiments are clearly defined, they can be effectively used as benchmarks for comparing and developing new forecasting models (e.g., Serafini et al., 2025).

107 ▪ Support continuous evaluation of Operational Earthquake Forecasting systems that
 108 provide authoritative, near-real-time forecasts (e.g., Jordan et al., 2011; Mizrahi et
 109 al., 2024). However, most systems generate forecasts for overlapping windows (e.g.,
 110 weekly forecasts updated daily) and evaluating the overall performance of such forecast
 111 collections remains an open methodological challenge (e.g., Brehmer et al., 2025).

112 floatCSEP contributes to a growing CSEP software ecosystem that, together with reproducibility
 113 packages (e.g., Allison et al., 2018; Bayona et al., 2022, 2023; Graham et al., 2024; Iturrieta et
 114 al., 2024; Savran, Bayona, et al., 2022), open-source forecasting models (e.g., Mizrahi et al.,
 115 2023), and long-term open-science repositories, could lay the foundation for building robust,
 116 collaborative benchmarks in earthquake forecasting.

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 127

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